Reading passage: “The Lantern Path”

Grade 8 English · fictional passage for practice

Mara had counted the stairs to the lamp room a thousand times, but tonight she counted them aloud, as if the numbers might hold the tower up against the wind. Her father had gone down to the harbor at dusk to help a stranded boat, and the storm had arrived early.

“Keep the light turning,” he had told her, tying his coat. “Whatever else happens, keep it turning.” So when the old clockwork stuck halfway through the night, Mara did not run for help. She wedged her shoulder against the great brass gear and pushed, one slow quarter-turn at a time, until her arms shook and the beam swept the black water again.

At dawn her father found her asleep against the rail, her hands wrapped in torn sleeves. He did not praise her. He only looked at the sea, where the stranded boat rocked safely at anchor, and said quietly, “I saw the light the whole way.” Mara smiled without opening her eyes.

Assignment and rubric

Prompt: Write one paragraph explaining how the author shows Mara’s character. Use at least two pieces of evidence from the passage.

Rubric (4 points each)

Claim: a strong answer states a clear claim about Mara’s character in the first sentence.

Evidence: a strong answer supports the claim with accurate quotations or close paraphrases from the passage.

Reasoning: a strong answer explains how each piece of evidence proves the claim, not just what happens.

Organization: a strong answer has a topic sentence, logical order, transitions and a concluding sentence.

Note from your teacher: bring a highlighted copy of the passage on the day of the writing assessment.